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VILLASEÑOR & AUWAE PLLC
Immigration Counsel
88 Truckee Row, Suite 700 · Reno, NV 89501
Tel. (775) 555-0164 · rov@villasenor-auwae.example

November 14, 2025

USCIS Nebraska Service Center
P.O. Box 87400
Lincoln, NE 68501-7400

RE: Form I-140, Immigrant Petition for Alien Worker
Classification: Advanced Degree Professional — National Interest Waiver, INA § 203(b)(2)(B)
Self-Petitioner and Beneficiary: Dr. Ilona Marta Brasch (Estonia)
Attorney of record: Renata O. Villaseñor, Esq. (Form G-28 enclosed)

Dear Officer:

This office represents Dr. Ilona Marta Brasch, who self-petitions for classification as a member of the professions holding an advanced degree and requests a national interest waiver of the job offer and labor certification requirements.

Dr. Brasch is a chemical engineer who develops layered-sorbent membrane modules that pull lithium out of geothermal brine at the wellhead. She is the founder and Chief Technology Officer of Halide Loop Technologies, Inc., a Nevada-based company she formed to bring that process into field use in the Great Basin. This petition is filed without an employer sponsor.

1. CONTENTS OF THIS FILING

Item	Description
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—	Form I-140, signed and dated November 10, 2025
—	Form G-28, Notice of Entry of Appearance
—	Filing fee, check no. 10442
Exhibit A	Statement of Proposed Endeavor by Dr. Ilona Marta Brasch
Exhibit B	Curriculum Vitae of Dr. Ilona Marta Brasch
Exhibit C	Citation and Adoption Report, prepared October 2025
Exhibit D	Letters of Support (three letters)
Exhibit E	Evidence of Commercial and Governmental Interest

2. LEGAL STANDARD

Section 203(b)(2)(B)(i) of the Act permits the Attorney General to waive the job offer requirement, and therefore the labor certification, for a member of the professions holding an advanced degree when the waiver is in the national interest. The framework is set out in *Matter of Dhanasar**, 26 I&N Dec. 884 (AAO 2016). The standard of proof is

preponderance of the evidence. *Matter of Chawathe*, 25 I&N Dec. 369, 376 (AAO 2010).

3. PRONG ONE — SUBSTANTIAL MERIT AND NATIONAL IMPORTANCE

The proposed endeavor is described in full at Exhibit A. In short, Dr. Brasch will continue to develop, field-test, and place into commercial operation a direct lithium extraction module that recovers battery-grade lithium from geothermal brine without evaporation ponds and without shipping brine off site.

The merit of the endeavor is technical and economic. Lithium is a designated critical mineral, and the overwhelming share of refined supply is produced outside the United States. Domestic geothermal brine in the Great Basin carries lithium at concentrations that conventional evaporation cannot economically address, and evaporation is in any event unavailable at the water budgets prevailing in northern Nevada. The endeavor is directed at a supply constraint that reaches beyond any single firm: it affects domestic cell manufacturing, grid storage procurement, and the operators of geothermal plants that today reinject a saleable mineral back into the ground.

The endeavor's importance is national rather than local. The process is not tied to one resource area; it applies to brines across the Basin and Range and to oilfield produced water in other states, as Exhibit A explains at section 4.

4. PRONG TWO — WELL POSITIONED TO ADVANCE THE ENDEAVOR

Dr. Brasch holds a doctorate in chemical engineering and has worked on selective ion capture for eleven years (Exhibit B). She is the sole first author of the sorbent chemistry underlying the module, and her published work has been taken up by researchers with no connection to her, as the citation record at Exhibit C documents in detail.

She has moved beyond publication into working hardware. Exhibit A, section 5, records the bench and skid milestones already met, including 1,900 hours of continuous operation on real brine drawn from an operating field. Exhibit D contains statements from three individuals familiar with the work. Exhibit E documents the interest that her results have drawn from a regional water authority, a geothermal operator, and a state innovation fund.

5. PRONG THREE — ON BALANCE, THE WAIVER BENEFITS THE UNITED STATES

No employer exists to sponsor her, and none realistically could. Dr. Brasch is a self-petitioner. She is the founder and Chief Technology Officer of Halide Loop Technologies, Inc., the company through which the endeavor is carried out, and she holds a controlling interest in it. A labor certification tests whether a United States worker is available for a position offered by an employer. There is no employer here other than the company Dr. Brasch herself created, and requiring her to obtain an offer from a third party would require her to abandon the endeavor in order to qualify to pursue it.

The labor certification test does not measure what matters here. The question the certification process answers — whether a qualified United States worker is available for a defined position — is not the question this endeavor turns on. What the endeavor depends on is the specific sorbent chemistry Dr. Brasch developed and the operating knowledge accumulated across four years of runs on real brine. A comparably credentialed engineer hired into a defined position would not carry that work forward; the work would

begin again.

Delay carries a concrete cost. The Nevada Division of Minerals has set the closing date for the second round of geothermal brine mineral lease applications at March 31, 2027 (Exhibit A, section 6). An applicant must demonstrate an operating recovery method at the time of application. If Dr. Brasch cannot direct the field program through 2026, the lease round passes and the demonstration site is lost for the term of the leases awarded.

The benefit does not depend on scarcity. Even accepting that other qualified chemical engineers are available in the United States, the benefit at issue is not the filling of a vacancy. It is the continuation of a specific line of work that has already produced a functioning module and that responds to a documented national supply problem.

6. CONCLUSION

The evidence establishes, by a preponderance, that the proposed endeavor has substantial merit and national importance, that Dr. Brasch is well positioned to advance it, and that it would benefit the United States to waive the job offer requirement in her case. We respectfully request approval of the petition.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Renata O. Villaseñor
Renata O. Villaseñor, Esq.
Counsel for the Petitioner